final. They had heard about the world-record partnership and wanted to see if we were good enough to have a career in cricket. Dilip Vengsarkar, Sunil Gavaskar and CCI president Raj Singh Dungarpur were in attendance and I did not want to disappoint them.

On the eve of the final I was given a superb gift by Hemant Kenkre, Sunil Gavaskar's nephew, which served as an added incentive to perform well. At the time I did not have good pads to play with and Sir had a word with Hemant about it. Hemant had with him a set of pads used by Sunil Gavaskar, the really light ones with blue padding inside, and decided to give them to me. I was delighted and humbled and went with Ajit to his house to collect my gift.

I felt very proud to wear pads once used by Sunil Gavaskar. I went in to bat thirty minutes before lunch on the first day of the final and kept batting for close to two days. I was eventually unbeaten on 346 when we were bowled out before tea on the third day. It was a very significant innings in the context of my career, for shortly afterwards I was included in the list of Probables for the Mumbai Ranji Trophy team.

In my early days as a cricketer another person who helped me considerably was Hemant Waingankar. Hemant, a student of my father's, knew me as a child and has followed my career from start to finish. It was at Hemant's initiative that Anil Joshi, Vijay Shirke and Sanju Khamkar of Sungrace Mafatlal, a well-known Indian company, came forward to support both Vinod and me with cricket equipment. I am glad that our friendship, which is now close to three decades old, continues even today.

My Sir

Looking back at these years of cricket, I must say I owe a lot to my coach Ramakant Achrekar – as well as his assistants, Das Shivalkar and Laxman Chavan. Had it not been for Sir, I would not be the cricketer I turned out to be. He was a strict disciplinarian and did everything he could for me.

On certain days he would even drive me all the way across Mumbai on his scooter to get me to matches on time. Even though I loved cricket, there were still occasional days when playing with my friends at home was such fun that I would conveniently forget I was supposed to go to the nets. If I didn't turn up, Achrekar Sir would jump on his scooter and